

Chapter 4: Exchange and Obligation

Exchange is the movement of goods, services, or people between social units. Anthropologists distinguish three principal modes: reciprocity, redistribution, and market exchange.

Reciprocity is the mutual give and take between parties of roughly equal standing. It is the dominant mode in societies without centralized authority.

Redistribution requires a center. Goods flow inward to a chief, a temple, or a state, and then flow outward again according to a principle the center controls.

Market exchange sets prices through the interaction of supply and demand, and it does not require an ongoing relationship between the parties.

4.1 Forms of Reciprocity

Generalized reciprocity involves giving without any specified expectation of return. It predominates within households and among close kin.

Balanced reciprocity involves an explicit expectation of return of equivalent value within a defined period. It predominates between trading partners.

Negative reciprocity is the attempt to get something for nothing. It predominates between strangers and enemies.

The three forms grade into one another along a continuum of social distance. As social distance increases, reciprocity becomes more balanced and then more negative.

4.2 The Kula Ring

The kula is a system of ceremonial exchange described by Malinowski among the Massim peoples of Papua New Guinea.

Two classes of valuables circulate in opposite directions around a ring of islands. Necklaces travel clockwise and armshells travel counterclockwise.

The valuables are not consumed and are not permanently owned. A participant holds an object temporarily and is obligated to pass it onward.

Prestige accrues to the participant through whose hands the most valuable objects have passed, not through accumulation.

Roughly 80 percent of kula voyages in Malinowski's account also carried ordinary trade goods, so ceremonial and utilitarian exchange were bundled.